



YOUR KINDLE NOTES FOR:

Scam Me If You Can: Simple Strategies to Outsmart Today's Rip-off Artists

by Frank W. Abagnale

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156 Highlights | 20 Notes

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 161

Law enforcement experts say there is a discernible link between meth addiction and ID theft.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 169

Experts say the effects of fraud on individuals are similar to the psychological aftermath experienced by victims of violent crimes and war, ranging from anxiety to emotional volatility, depression to post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 197

I became a con artist in 1964, at the age of sixteen, and continued until I was caught and brought to justice in 1969, when I was just twenty-one. In those intervening years, even though I was very young, I was able to don a variety of professional disguises and professions, including airline pilot, doctor, lawyer, sociology professor, FBI agent, and Federal Bureau of Prisons agent. This is the story depicted in my 1980 book *Catch Me If You Can*, which in 2002 became a Steven Spielberg film of the same name, featuring Leonardo DiCaprio as me. (If you watch closely, you'll see me make an appearance as a French cop!) I traveled the world, cashing more than \$2.5 million in forged checks, and as a result I financed a lifestyle that included bespoke suits, luxury cars, and world travel. I dated beautiful women. It was thrilling. First I assumed the identity of a Pan Am copilot.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 205

I was tall, which made me appear older, nicely dressed, and very polite. I knew that certain kinds of people were more apt to come under my spell than others. Pretty young women, older people, and those who felt I represented authority were all good targets. Young women because, well . . . I liked them and they liked me. Older people were always impressed with a well-spoken and courteous young man. And all sorts of people—airline and airport staff, people in banks and other institutions—respected someone in a pilot's uniform.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 221

I've now been a security and anti-fraud consultant for more than forty-three years. I have a consulting company, Abagnale & Associates. My fraud prevention programs are used by more than fourteen thousand financial

institutions, corporations, and law enforcement agencies. I've met and talked to thousands of everyday people who have been harmed by scams—from small business owners to CEOs, from students to retirees, and everyone in between, people of all ages and from all backgrounds, around the world—hearing their stories and offering advice. This has allowed me to cover a wide variety of scams, investigate where they come from, and find ways to fight back against this worldwide scourge.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 227

My goal with Scam Me If You Can is to arm as many people as I can with the information and tools you need to put a shield between you and the scammers.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 229

It's such important information to have on hand, because we are living in a unique time. At no other point in history has it been easier to be a con artist—or to be victimized by one. In the past decade, technology has completely transformed the landscape of scams, making them quicker, more global, more anonymous, and more interconnected than ever before.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 235

The good news is that fraud is preventable. Vigilance is your weapon, and it is always at your disposal.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 250

Active in more sales situations: Victims tend to be more engaged in the marketplace—whether that is the consumer marketplace (such as shopping or investing in the stock market) or the marketplace of ideas (social media). They are more likely to report attending sales presentations when offered a free meal or hotel stay in return; entering their name in drawings to win a prize; allowing salespeople into their homes to make a presentation; and opening and reading every piece of mail they receive—catalogs, advertising circulars, contests offerings, and promotional come-ons.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 255

Slow to take preventative actions: Victims are less likely than the general population to report taking prevention measures

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 256

checking the references of businesses before hiring them.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 257

Under more stress: We have to be especially cautious in our decision-making during stressful events or when life is putting great demands on us. That's because stress takes up cognitive capacity, which means we may not be thinking about how to defend ourselves against scams.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 263

five simple steps you can take to scam-proof your life. Protect your identity Secure your finances Preserve your digital presence Safeguard your home and hearth Shelter your heart

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 278

signing up for AARP's Fraud Watch Network.

He sure likes to sell/market AARP so beware

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 359

160 to 190 points: You

Scored 17/20 or 170... and can quibble with a bit of his phrasing

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 373

Con men like Kevin are well trained in the techniques to get targets "under the ether." Ether is a condition of trust and even infatuation with what is being presented.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 375

To get their victims under the ether, fraudsters hit their fear, panic, and urgency buttons.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 383

Nancy answered Kevin's call because it looked like it came from a local Florida area code, not an 800 number, like many previous calls she'd received (and hadn't answered). The area code made her feel that the call was legitimate.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 395

The best con artists know how to use a comforting and confident tone of voice to get people under the ether. They prey on vulnerabilities and seduce their victims into revealing their personal information. I perfected this technique while running scams as a young man. I knew how to modulate my voice and speak in a calm and reassuring manner to all my targets. The effect was almost hypnotic—before

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 399

a good con should always try "to keep the victim up in the altitude of the ether, because once they drop into the valley of logic, [you've] lost them."

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 402

To induce the ether, the con artist asks questions that trigger emotional responses.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 403

asking Nancy about her concerns about the cost of the unit and whether she would be able to carve out enough time to use it that it would be worthwhile in the future.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 406

In a home improvement scam, the con might ask the victim if it has been frustrating to deal with needed repairs. Once a con identifies your triggers, he uses them as part of the pitch to drive you to a heightened emotional state.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 416

Instead of asking, “What’s your monthly mortgage payment?” which would put the target on edge, the con might gently say, “Let me ask you something. It sounds like you have a wonderful home there. How much is that mortgage each month?” Instead of “When did your spouse die?” he said, “I know you loved your husband very much and miss him terribly. If you don’t mind my asking, how long has he been gone?” Once the emotions and memories come flooding into the target’s mind, the target connects those feelings to the person on the other end of the phone. The con has become a “friend,” so the target opens up, answering personal questions and, more important, starting to trust the con.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 422

HOW TO AVOID TRUSTING SOMEONE YOU SHOULDN’T Never engage a stranger in dialogue about your personal life. Don’t reveal any personal information—not just account information but also names of family, friends, and even pets. Every time a stranger asks you a personal question, ask this question in return: Why do you need to know? Remember that you don’t owe anything to a stranger—not information, consent to buy what they are selling, or anything else.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 427

HITTING YOUR SCARCITY AND URGENCY BUTTONS, WITH A TOUCH OF FLATTERY THROWN IN

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 430

Psychology professor Robert Cialdini popularized the term “scarcity principle” to explain how people are enticed by opportunities that seem finite or fleeting. Scarcity is often paired with urgency (You must act now!) and flattery (You’re too smart to let a deal this great get away!).

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 450

TEN WAYS TO AVOID THE TRIPLE THREAT: SCARCITY, URGENCY, AND FLATTERY Check your emotions. If you are approached with a pitch to win a large amount of money or become part of a limited-time-only investment opportunity or send money to someone you haven't met, pay attention to your reaction. Is your heart racing? Are you excited? Do you start dreaming of all the things you could do with the money? These kinds of reactions are signs that you may be under the ether. Don't make a decision in this emotional state. Give it twenty-four hours. Make it a nonnegotiable personal rule to give yourself one full day to think about any financial decision. This will diminish the emotion attached to the pitch and give you time to think without any pressure from anyone else. Practice introspection. As enticing as the offer may sound, pull yourself back into logic mode by asking yourself a few questions, including: What's in this deal for the person asking? How does it benefit him? Does it make sense that I am getting this offer? Why me? How will this offer benefit me in the long run? Are there better, more reliable, or familiar alternatives to this offer? Keep it close to the vest. Don't answer personal questions, especially about your family situation, finances, or worries. Don't share personal information with people you don't know or haven't met in person. Get nosy. Always ask more questions than you answer. Put the caller on the spot with questions, including details about the offer, why the person called you, his or her credentials and street address, and so on. Don't fall for time limits. When approached with an offer that is available for a limited time or is in limited supply, remind yourself that limited-time offers are rarely legitimate. Even supermarkets put grocery items on sale in weekly rotation! If you don't get the eggs on sale this week, you can get them on sale in a few weeks. Do due diligence. Take the time to research the offer, the person, or the company. Read reviews. I always look at a seller's feedback in forums and on consumer websites. Check ratings with business rating organizations and consumer groups. Evaluate any complaints or negative feedback about the company or seller. When it comes to financial investments, such as purchasing currency like coins, don't risk it if there's even one negative complaint. Tell someone. If you or anyone you know is being harassed by someone you believe to be a con artist (or by anyone, for that matter), contact law enforcement and file a report. Don't pick up. You don't have to answer your calls. Screen them, and don't call back. Stay informed.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 477

You can do that easily, for free, by joining the Fraud Watch Network (AARP.org/FraudWatch Network).

Selling again

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 486

Don't get swept up in desperation or quick fixes. Look for alternatives. Before you make a decision about something, even if the answer seems promising in terms of fulfilling a need, think about alternatives. Is there something better? Question up-front fees.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 490

Never send untraceable money. Don't pay any fees through cash or a wire transfer, money order, gift card, or certified bank or cashier's check. These payment methods are difficult to recover. Check your credit card company's dispute policy. Many

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 496

Demand everything in writing. Don't agree to anything without paperwork.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 696

Say no to offers. Opt out of receiving pre-screened offers of credit and junk mail in general. Call 888-5-OPT-OUT or visit www.optoutprescreen.com. This service is legitimate, since it is run by the credit-reporting companies.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 873

Personally, I think it's a good idea for everyone to freeze their credit for extra security. And it's now very easy to do, because in September 2018, credit freezes became free in the United States. Now you can place and lift freezes for free at all credit agencies, and the agencies must comply with your request within one day of your online or phone notification or within three days of receiving a mailed request. To set up a credit freeze online, go to the freeze page at each of the three agencies websites (see the Resources section for contact information). They will provide you with a PIN that you can use to lift or reinstate the freeze in the future.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 927

Provide your Social Security number only when it's absolutely required. If someone asks you for it—in a doctor's office, for example—ask if it's necessary.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 929

Go to www.ssa.gov/myaccount and establish online access to information about your Social Security benefits, review your earnings history, on which your benefits are based, and request replacement documents when necessary.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 935

If you discover that your Social Security number has been compromised, notify the Federal Trade Commission (FTC). See

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 968

The IRS won't call you before writing to you first. Be suspicious the minute you receive an unexpected call from someone claiming to be an IRS agent or representative.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 971

The IRS won't threaten you over the phone with immediate retribution. Fake IRS calls typically make threats that the IRS would never make, such as saying they'll arrest you immediately, freeze all your assets (although

the IRS can freeze your assets, they won't do it over the phone; due process is always involved), revoke your driver's license, or change your immigration status.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 975

Delete emails purporting to be from the IRS, and don't click on links in these emails. The IRS doesn't send out unsolicited emails

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 978

If you have reason to believe a tax-related call might be legitimate, call the IRS Taxpayer Assistance Center (TAC) closest to you and ask if an IRS representative has contacted you. But beware of getting a call from a TAC. In 2018, the IRS issued a warning about a new twist on an old phone scam. In this one, criminals program their computers to display the TAC telephone number on your caller ID to convince you that you are getting an authentic call,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1234

RESOURCES: MEDICARE IDENTITY THEFT If you receive Medicare and think that you have been a victim of medical identity theft, you have dedicated resources available. Report suspicious calls regarding your healthcare or health insurance to 800-MEDICARE (800-633-4227). Each state has a Senior Medicare Patrol (SMP) that can give you reliable information and help with all your Medicare questions, including those about possible fraud or identity theft. You can locate your state's office at www.smpresource.org/content/what-smps-do.aspx. Staff here will also help you determine whether fraud or theft has occurred. If you have established that someone else is using your Medicare benefits, follow the same procedure as with any other kind of identity theft and begin by making a report at www.identitytheft.gov.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1328

HOW TO RECOGNIZE A PONZI SCHEME The promise of low or no risk and high returns:

High no risk. Consistent. Unregistered investment. Unlicensed seller. Complex/secret strategies.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1529

Use AARP's guide to interviewing an adviser (www.aarp.org/interviewanadviser) and record the answers. To get better educated about investing, visit www.nasaa.org/investor-education. And use my quick guide below to get started asking questions.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1532

What are your credentials? Misrepresentation of credentials can be a way for scammers to convince you they are qualified to handle your money,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1541

Certified Public Accountant: CPAs are licensed by the state after meeting education and experience requirements. They can offer financial planning as well as a variety of accounting services such as tax preparation.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1544

Registered Investment Adviser: An RIA is an adviser registered either with the SEC or state securities authorities. RIAs have a fiduciary duty to their clients,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1552

Are you a fiduciary? When a planner is a fiduciary, it means he or she has an obligation to operate with your best interests in mind.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1556

What certifications do you have? Once you get the answers, a simple background check at BrokerCheck (brokercheck.org) or the Certified Financial Planner Board (www.cfp.net) can tell you if your planner has been disciplined in the past and if credentials are up to date. Go to www.finra.org and www.sec.gov to see whether any regulatory actions have been taken against your planner and to find out whether he or she is registered with your state

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1564

At www.investor.gov, you can get more tips on how to invest wisely,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1567

In addition to www.investor.gov, the SEC has websites that will help you determine whether an investment opportunity is legitimate. The

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1572

If you believe you have been scammed, contact the FTC online at www.ftc.gov

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1587

registered with Sunbiz, the state's business filing department. Karen paid the \$75 fee for registering her business and decided not to pay extra for the optional paper business certificate. A week after registering, Karen received an official-looking letter in the mail, complete with the Florida state seal on the return address, saying she had to purchase a paper certificate for her business for a whopping \$67.25. She wisely looked closer and found some extremely fine print that read, "This is not a government agency." A for-profit, private company called FL

Certificate Services was simply trying to fool her into thinking she needed to buy a certificate—a worthless eight-by-ten piece of paper. Two days later, she received a similar solicitation from a different company, also official-looking. This one wanted her to send \$78 for the same certificate.

Receive these each year

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1609

Another way scammers try to collect money is by sending you an item that you did not order and then demanding payment for it.

Like miami herald

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1695

Complain to authorities. File a complaint with the FTC. You can do that by going to www.ftc.gov/complaint.

Should do this with miami herald

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 1729

criminals pose as tech support, calling your company and claiming there's a problem with your computer and they need remote access to fix it.

How many people have asked me about this...

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1780

If your business or organization receives a suspect email requesting W-2 data, report it immediately to the IRS. Send the full email to phishing@irs.gov and use "W2 Scam" in the subject line. If your business has been victimized by one of these W-2 phishing scams, notify the IRS as soon as you discover the breach.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1806

Use one-stop pay options. Instead of writing checks, I recommend using bill-pay features via your vendors or bank or going paperless.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1809

Set up alerts. You may be able to set up alerts for any transaction over, say, \$1.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1810

Check it. Monitor your accounts

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1846

The court never calls people who do not show up for jury duty, and it does not require them to buy money cards at supermarkets to pay fines.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1853

The scammer asks for information to verify your identity: Social Security number, birthdate, and sometimes mother's maiden name and banking information—in short, all the information needed to steal your identity and your money.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1855

the court, as a rule, will not call you if you missed jury duty, and neither will it call asking for personal information. Instead, courts generally send notifications through the mail. Since more states are cracking down on no-show jurors, you could be served with court papers for not appearing. This is done by mail, by courier, or, in rare instances, in person by a process server.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1882

If you receive Facebook messages about government grants, you should immediately report the scam to Facebook and the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3), at www.ic3.gov. If the message came from a Facebook friend, let that person know that his or her Facebook account has been hacked.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1896

FIVE IMPORTANT RULES ABOUT REAL GOVERNMENT GRANTS

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1897

All government grant applications and information about them are free and available online at www.grants.gov. In fact, this is the only official clearinghouse for information about government-based grants.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1899

The names of other local and national nonprofit, nongovernment organizations, agencies, and foundations that award grants are available for free at any public library or on the Internet.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1901

The government never charges fees to apply for government grants.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1902

All government grants are for projects with a purpose that benefits the public and are never intended for personal use, to pay off bills or purchase personal items.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1904

The government will never contact you to solicit a grant application or to ask for payment for processing a grant. No fees are associated with government grants.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1937

Sometimes the scammers say they are from the “National Consumer Protection Agency” or the “National Sweepstakes Bureau,” both of which are fake organizations. Sometimes they say they are calling from the Federal Trade Commission, which is a real entity—but the calls are fake. No government agency will do any such thing. If you buy a lottery ticket, it’s up to you to come forward to claim your prize.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1963

SIX SAVVY STRATEGIES FOR BEATING A GOVERNMENT IMPOSTOR SCAM Never wire money. Scammers often try to bully people into wiring money to a bank account or putting money on a prepaid debit card and sending it to them. Don’t do this. Don’t pay a fee to get a grant or sweepstakes winnings. If you have to pay to collect a grant or sweepstakes money, it’s a scam. Don’t give unknown callers financial information.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1971

Verify ID. If someone claims to be from the government, a local agency, or a utility, ask for identification in person or an ID number over the phone. Then verify the information by calling the agency he or she claims to be from—and

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 1974

Report the scam. If you think you have received a fraudulent government phone call or letter, file a complaint at www.ftc.gov/complaint. Be sure to include: Date and time of the call. Scanned copy of the letter if applicable. Name of the government agency the impostor used. What the caller said, including the amount of money you supposedly owe or won, as well as the payment method requested. Phone number of the caller. Even though scammers use spoofing to simulate real numbers, or create fake ones, law enforcement agents can still potentially track a number to identify the caller. Any other details from the call.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2008

I predict that technology will be used as a tool by terrorists who want to do physical harm to people. Today we can shut off someone’s pacemaker or commandeer a car from thirty-five feet away. In the not too distant future, we’ll be able to do those things from five hundred or five thousand miles away.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2011

social media websites are not necessarily good things: If you can control the psychology of two billion people, the risk of real harm becomes insidious.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2025

The most common defense against malware is to install antivirus software on your digital devices. But, said Garfinkel, “antivirus software only works against threats that are well known. Today, targeted threats increasingly involve new, unpublicized threats.”

So old adage and over simplified

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2097

Botnet: A botnet is a kind of robot that works over a network.

Bleh!

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2118

Sometimes these devices generate a number like a PIN to the owner to access a device. The security token can also be called a Universal Serial Bus (USB) token, cryptographic token, hardware token, hard token, authentication token, or key fob.

Ahhh. How about explaining the concept of 2FA...

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2195

The PSA recommends that consumers take the following steps to protect the cybersecurity of their vehicle:

Does not seem up-to-date ala Tesla (where it's most relevant)

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2361

First they called Mckesson’s telephone company, Verizon, claiming to be him. The hackers “verified” their faux identity with a company representative by correctly confirming static, secret questions such as the last four digits of his Social Security number—information gleaned from online research and social engineering (that is, manipulating someone into revealing personal information). Once cleared, the hackers successfully registered a different SIM card in place of Mckesson’s, which redirected incoming text messages to their own phone. This allowed them to easily hijack any passcode they wanted to obtain and gain access to his private accounts—in this case, Twitter. This growing strain of cybercrime is referred to as SIM swap.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2485

Many fund-raisers claiming to be calling on behalf of your local police or fire department are bogus. If you want to support your local cops and firefighters, call them directly to ask where to send a donation.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2493

What exposes each call as fraudulent is the request—or sometimes threatening demand—for personal or financial information. The best way to deal with such a call: Don't answer. If you don't recognize the number, don't pick up.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2499

If the call is from an unsolicited "live" caller, hang up. If you don't recognize the voice, hang up. Never, ever respond by giving your information to a caller.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2556

Add your phone number for free by visiting www.donotcall.gov or calling 888-382-1222 (TTY: 866-290-4236) from the phone you want to register. You can register up to three numbers. After you register, other types of organizations may still call you, such as charities, political groups, debt collectors, and pollsters, as well as companies you've recently done business with or given written permission to call you. But the truth is, the registry only helps with companies that are legitimately trying to sell you something, not scam artists.

And this is the key... The bad guys dont heed it. And if they had access its simply a valid list

Note | Location 2560

Again... I suspect this just validates your #

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2560

The best way to avoid scam calls and reduce your chances of receiving them in the future is to simply not answer the phone if there is a number you don't recognize on your caller ID. By letting these calls go to voicemail, you'll often find that no message has been left; this is a sign that the caller was simply looking for a live number.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2576

But here's the problem with these apps: Putting a blanket block on all unknown numbers and anonymous numbers can block legitimate callers as well.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2595

third-party apps that filter calls. Most of these collect a sort of blacklist of scammers' numbers and block them before the call comes through. Here are some you may want to look into: Hiya, Mr. Number, Nomorobo, RoboKiller, Truecaller, and YouMail. One last option is a call-blocking device attached to traditional landlines. Brands include CPR, Digitone, Mcheeta, Sentry, and Tel-Lynx. These boxes, generally under \$100,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2603

caller will ask you to confirm your billing information, which he says he already has. He reads it to you and asks you if it's correct. Once you say "Yes," he or she has gotten your consent. Or he or she will simply ask, "Can you hear me?" and record you saying "Yes," then use that voice recording to authorize fraudulent charges by telephone.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2615

Ignore it. Just don't pick up if you don't recognize the number.

Benn doing that for years since callerID

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2617

Be tight-lipped. If you do pick up a call from an unknown number, say nothing. Your voice launches robocall recordings or transfers to call centers, where a live operator will try to get your personal and financial information. Saying nothing usually disconnects robocalls within seconds, and generally you won't get a call back from this number. If the call is from an unsolicited "live" caller, let the caller break the silence. If you don't recognize the voice, hang up.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2627

Hang up. If you think it may be legit, call back on a number you find independently.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2628

Research shows that robocalls tend to be made more frequently on Fridays and Tuesdays. Be on heightened alert on those days.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2645

One-ring calls are a common ruse to prompt you to call the number back to find out what the call was about. Be especially aware of one-ring calls from area codes 268, 284, 809, and 876, which originate from Caribbean countries with high per-minute phone charges. If you get a one-ring call, don't call back.

Would never. But will warch for those are codes to see if theres any truth... He sounds like a scammer to me. Lots o stories in attempt to build cred....

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2678

In 1967, the Florida Land Sales Board charged the Gulf American Land Corporation and the Rosens with deceptive and misleading promotion and sales methods. The brothers had defrauded 1,300 buyers by selling them partly drained wetlands—land

Every example is in FL :-)!!! No surprise there...

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2703

“I politely asked him for proof he was who he said he was (the homeowner), and his response was basically, ‘You can trust me, I’m a Christian, I give you my word.’” Once Hillary asked to see a copy of the title of the property and a utility bill, he stopped responding. “That’s when I knew it was a scam,” she said. Hillary quickly reported the fraudulent listing to Craigslist as well as to the complex where the alleged apartment was located.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2730

Also check for what is called “scammer grammar”—a poor command of the English language and frequent misspellings, particularly in any follow-up communication you may receive concerning a well-worded (and likely copied) advertisement.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2734

Go local, and go face-to-face. According to Craigslist, follow this one rule and you’ll avoid 99 percent of scams.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2738

Email is the preferred communication of scammers.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2740

Arrange for a video call via Skype or FaceTime so you can see the person. Ask for proof. If you are dealing with a property owner, ask for proof of ownership, such as a copy of the title or utility bill, and identity, such as a driver’s license.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2763

Do a double take. Use Google Images or <https://tineye.com> to search by image, making sure the photo of the property isn’t taken from a legitimate source.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2783

dealing directly with hotels can often get you the best hotel room rates, especially if you add in membership discounts (like AARP or AAA).

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2788

When a reviewer complains about something in the review, does the owner respond, and are they gracious and apologetic or are they defensive? Defensiveness could be a red flag for an owner who is unconcerned about repeat customers or good property management. Question

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2805

If you're interested in selling a timeshare, follow these tips. Check with your resort about resale or buyback programs. Expect to pay 10 to 30 percent in commission. Deal with reputable, well-known local real estate agents who have a demonstrable track record of resales. Never go with a company that charges up-front fees. When listing a timeshare yourself, stick with a legitimate website like RedWeek or TUG (Timeshare Users Group). HOME

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2817

a change of season is a time when many of us do home repairs and major maintenance jobs, so this is when door-to-door home repair solicitations reach a peak.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2866

Sign a contract. Don't hire a contractor who tells you there's no need for a written contract. Legally, contracts for \$500 or more must be confirmed in writing, but it's a good idea to have a written contract for smaller projects, too.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2867

Look for a real address. Avoid contractors who have just a post office box or a cell phone number. Look for a street address and a business phone number.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2869

Don't pay cash. Never give a contractor cash for a job. If a contractor balks at the surcharge that credit card companies add, I offer to pay the 3 or 4 percent. That is a very inexpensive insurance policy against poor workmanship or no-shows—if the arrangement falls through, you can go to the credit card company and get your money back.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2873

Have the contractor pull permits. Don't use a contractor who requires you to pull permits for a job. This is a sign that the contractor is unlicensed or has had run-ins with the building inspector. If permits are necessary for the project, obtaining them should be part of the contractor's job.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2876

Don't pay for materials up front. Be wary of contractors who ask for money to buy materials before starting the job. Reliable, established contractors can buy materials on credit. Don't work with a contractor who demands full payment up front.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2878

Withhold final payment. Don't pay for the job in full until it is completed properly, necessary inspectors have signed off, and you approve of the work done. Sue in criminal court. If you do get ripped off by a shady contractor, civil court judgments are difficult, if not impossible, to collect. Talk to your local law enforcement or district attorney's office to see if criminal charges can be applied to your problem.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2962

Here's what to do if you get a call from someone claiming to be a family member in need. Hit the pause button. Calm yourself, be skeptical, and say you will have to consult another family member before taking any action.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2969

Probe. Question the callers without giving up any information—expect them to provide it. In Rich's case, he asked for his grandson's address, which the scammers didn't know, so they hung up. Asking for details without providing any is a good way to find out if it's a scam. Eventually scammers will run up against a detail they do not know.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2972

Don't post bail. If you get a phone call asking you to post bail, don't pay anything over the phone or by wire transfer. Again, call any law enforcement office back on a number you locate independently and find out exactly where the person is detained and the booking status. You can also use the court's website to determine whether an arrest was actually made.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 2975

Follow the money. Pay close attention to how the person wants you to provide money. If it's by wire transfer via Western Union or MoneyGram, a prepaid debit card, or cash or check sent via courier, that's a red flag.

Intl shipping... Fraud for sure but had i not paid would shipment have disappeared?

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 2983

If it's a letter sent to your home or business address, it might be on heavy paper stock with an impressive bank seal in gold or platinum. It looks official—and important. Except, of course, it's a scam. The author of the correspondence will provide detailed instructions on how you can access this large sum of money if you reply.

But if you do, you will receive directions to wire a fee to the attorney’s account—just a mere percentage of the millions that will allegedly be coming to you. Your bank routing and account numbers are required, too—so that the lawyer representing the deceased relative can make sure those millions reach you safely. With this payment and information, your surprise inheritance can be processed. Phony inheritance scams have existed for decades

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3020

“There are a hundred reasons why a seventy-nine-year-old man with a terminal illness would change his will, and I would put elder financial abuse on the top of that list,”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3055

the Elder Abuse Prevention and Prosecution Act, which became law in 2017. It aims to help stem the tide of what its sponsor, Senator Chuck Grassley of Iowa, called “financial exploitation of America’s seniors . . . the crime of the 21st century.” The bill mandates increased penalties for fraud against people fifty-five and older, comprehensive training for FBI agents, elder justice coordinators in federal judicial districts and the FTC’s Bureau of Consumer Protection, a working group to provide policy advice, a resource group to assist U.S. prosecutors in pursuing elder abuse cases, and more. I think this is good news. Estate planning can be a complicated legal issue, so be sure to consult a trusted professional.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3062

“Having lived through this, and if I could do it again, I would say talk to your parents when they are still young,” John advised me. “My siblings and I should have gone to my father when he was sixty, or he to us. It would not have hurt my feelings if he had gone to one of my brothers or my sister and not me to discuss his will . . . Keep the lines of communication open.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3066

Have a plan. After you have a conversation, make a plan. Review that plan periodically—every five years or so.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3067

Think like a predator. Talk with your loved ones about the potential for people to take advantage of you or them.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3071

Check credentials and make sure professionals you’re considering have no complaints against them.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3072

Don’t go it alone. Never sign paperwork without consulting with your family or trusted advisers.

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 3081

Do an Internet search on the site name with “reviews” and “scams” and see what comes up.

Yep...

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3087

The names of professional genealogists, both certified and uncertified, can be obtained from the Association of Professional Genealogists (www.apgen.org).

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3121

the Internet can be a positive; it allows you to do quick information verifications.”

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Location 3150

Know the risks. Hacks happen every day, and in all kinds of ways. Before you swab your cheek or spit into a test tube, think about the risks associated with DNA testing and the fact that hackers could gain access to your information in a data breach.

Yep...

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3165

keep the lines of communication open between your loved ones. Discuss matters when they arise; don’t wait. Settle disputes quickly and fairly, and be willing to compromise.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3189

You can also check lists of the worst charities. These lists generally call out charities that allocate 4 percent or less of the donations

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3266

Adrienne Gonzalez, a reporter who investigates animal fraud and heads up a watchdog website called GoFraudMe,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3286

Don’t give to individuals or organizations you cannot check out. If

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3289

Volunteer! If you are able, volunteer at a local shelter or rescue mission. Giving your time and love to animals in need is one of the best ways to help.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3321

“Not long ago, I saw a Twitter account of someone claiming to be a gay teen whose ultra-religious parents were throwing her out of the house. She created a GoFundMe account that day and had collected \$4,000. The next day the account—and the money—was gone,” said Gonzalez. Whether this was real or made up, we’ll never know. Unless you can confirm that the stories are true and you know the money will be well spent, it’s better to decline to give, no matter how tragic the situation sounds.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3329

not to say there are no legitimate causes helped by GoFundMe and other for-profit online funding groups. There are. Discerning between good and bad, real and fake, is what can be challenging. Although crowdsourcing websites like GoFundMe or CrowdRise by GoFundMe do try to monitor what goes up on their site, keep in mind that these are businesses, not nonprofits. “An IRS-regulated charity may be a better bet,”

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3335

The organization or individual soliciting funds should be a legitimate 501(c)(3) charitable group. Ask to see an official letter from the IRS showing that it is registered and tax-exempt. The organization or individual should also be able to show you a copy of the IRS Form 990 or 990-EZ showing its financial reporting for each year. Or you can look it up on the IRS website. If the 501(c)(3) organization takes in more than \$20,000 per year, it would also have, and be able to produce upon request, annual returns and applications of exemption. If it is incorporated, articles of incorporation and bylaws should be available.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3340

Find out how much of the money is going to the stated mission. How many of your dollars actually get to the cause? The percentage you feel comfortable with is up to you. Charities know the exact percentages of dollars spent on fund-raising, salaries, and the cause itself.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3343

Find out about the charity’s specific good deeds. Don’t accept answers like “We educate the public” or “We raise awareness”—alone, those are empty and meaningless phrases. Look for specific projects that have quantifiable results.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3347

In March 2018, four people were indicted on charges of creating the Wounded Warrior Fund and Wounded Warrior Foundation, tricking donors into believing they were giving money to the Wounded Warrior Project (which has also come under fire for misappropriation of funds).

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3350

Similarly, a former New York stockbroker with ties to organized crime allegedly set up several bogus nonprofit organizations with legitimate-sounding names—the American Cancer Society of Washington, American Cancer Society of Seattle, American Red Cross of Seattle, American Red Cross of Washington, United Way of Seattle, and United Way of Washington—and by doing so obtained donations fraudulently. He kept donations for himself. Check

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3358

Don't let the pressure get to you. No reputable charity insists that you make a gift immediately.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3361

Check registration. Check to see if your state or the state where a disaster happened requires charities and fundraisers to be registered with the state by visiting the National Association of State Charity Officials (www.nasconet.org).

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3366

Designate your donation. If you know the charity is legitimate and you are ready to donate, you might want to designate exactly where you want your money going—for

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3373

paying by credit card is safest—but offer up credit card information only if you have initiated the donations. Don't give credit card information to unsolicited callers.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3423

While the FBI says that the most common targets are women over forty who are divorced, widowed, and/or disabled, it doesn't matter if you're male or female, old or young, gay or straight. Every age group and demographic is a potential target of a dating scam.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3477

Community is the key here—Caldwell sought out women in the hiking community, and Melissa was not his first victim. This is a type of affinity fraud, the same kind that financial scammers often use to lure victims into investment schemes (this page). Dating scammers use common interests and membership in groups to connect with people and establish a basic level of trust.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3494

use <https://tineye.com> or Google Images to “search by image” and see if that person's photo shows up in other places using a different name.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3496

Cut and paste suspicious wording into a search engine and see if the same words pop up

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3663

technology will become increasingly difficult to fool. If recognition analysts see an image that is associated with two or more identities, they try to determine whether it was a clerical error—for instance, from a name change due to marriage or divorce—or willful fraud. As of this writing, thirty-nine state DMVs use facial recognition software.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3667

In Massachusetts, self-service license renewal kiosks use biometrics to ensure that people are who they say they are—and raise the alarm if there’s a problem. Colorado, Idaho, Iowa, Maryland, and Washington, D.C., have all begun testing digital driver’s licenses (DDLs), which are encrypted and app-based, with remote reader technology—including facial recognition—to access the app.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3673

biometric, fingerprints, can also be used to make birth certificates and Social Security cards—and our identities—more secure and harder to steal.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3674

“There is no reason why a birth certificate cannot be issued, at birth, that contains a chip with the child’s fingerprint, since fingerprints are fully developed at birth,” said Benson. A patent for this technology was issued a few years ago,

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3694

bitcoin transactions cannot be changed or reversed—a feature of the currency, not a bug. I expect cryptocurrency scams to increase as cryptocurrencies like bitcoin become more popular.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3706

I strongly believe that blockchain is the future of secure data processing and storage and that it will greatly minimize and even potentially eliminate identity theft. It is the best way to secure information.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3709

The most important step you can take to prevent fraud is to educate yourself on the latest threats and frauds using the many resources available, including AARP’s Fraud Watch. Sign up at www.aarp.org/fraudwatchnetwork

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3711

Then follow the suggestions I've provided throughout this book. Freeze your credit. Clear your computer's browsing history regularly or use private windows when searching on the Internet. Keep track of your finances by reading bank and credit card statements carefully. Use a major credit card for all major transactions—and even small ones. Track your account regularly and question suspicious transactions. Use two-step authentication for passwords until the time comes when we can eliminate the need for passwords. Never share personal information with people you don't know, or on social media. Don't leave your smartphone unlocked. Shred sensitive documents using a micro-cut shredder. Read the fine print and understand what you are signing before making a financial commitment, whether it's an investment opportunity, property transaction, or charitable donation. When in doubt in considering a financial commitment, get a second opinion. Don't be embarrassed if you are a victim of fraud; report it to law enforcement and the AARP Fraud Watch Network. Vote for politicians who advocate for investment in national security systems to prevent "weaponless war" and other mass cyber scams and crimes. Advocate for local and state governments to institute technologies like biometrics and blockchain to protect identities.

Highlight (Yellow) | Location 3782

Resources AARP Fraud Watch Network 877-908-3360 www.aarp.org/fraudwatchnetwork Sign up for free watchdog alerts; get tips to spot and avoid scams like identity theft, investment fraud, and holiday scams; review a scam-tracking map that provides real-time alerts from law enforcement in your state; and call the toll-free fraud helpline to report fraud or speak with fraud counselors. Abagnale & Associates 800-237-7443 www.abagnale.com Frank Abagnale Jr. speaks widely about fraud. Contact him to learn more about hosting him for speaking engagements. Federal Trade Commission 600 Pennsylvania Avenue NW Washington, DC 20580 202-326-2222 www.ftc.gov You can report fraud at www.ftc.gov/complaint. Try to provide specifics, such as a copy of any letter or email you receive and the date and time of any calls, along with what the caller said and the phone number of the caller. Even though scammers use spoofing to simulate real numbers, or create fake ones, law enforcement agents can still potentially track numbers to identify the caller. For any type of identity theft, begin by making a report at www.identitytheft.gov. Financial Industry Regulatory Authority (FINRA) 1735 K Street NW Washington, DC 20006 301-590-6500 www.finra.org FINRA is an independent organization that upholds standards for broker-dealers. Its website provides resources for investors, including a way to file a complaint against a broker-dealer. Internal Revenue Service (IRS) 800-829-1040 www.irs.gov The IRS provides information on federal taxes, tax fraud and prevention, and related financial crimes. Medicare 800-MEDICARE (800-633-4227) TTY: 877-486-2048 www.medicare.gov/fraud Contact Medicare to find out how to spot and report Medicare-related fraud. Report suspicious calls regarding your healthcare or health insurance to Medicare's 800 number. Each state has a Senior Medicare Patrol (SMP) that can give you reliable information and help with all your Medicare questions, including those about possible fraud or identity theft. You can locate your state's office at www.smpresource.org/content/what-smps-do.aspx, or call 877-808-2468. Staff will also help you determine whether fraud or theft has occurred. If you have established that someone else is using your Medicare benefits, follow the same procedure as with any other kind of identity theft by making a report at www.identitytheft.gov. National Do Not Call Registry 888-382-1222 TTY: 866-290-4236 www.donotcall.gov Register your home and mobile numbers for free to stop unwanted sales calls from legitimate companies. You might still receive political calls, charitable calls, debt collection calls, informational calls, and telephone survey calls. Companies you've recently done business with may also call you, though if you ask them not to, they must

honor your request. Once your number is on the registry, if you do get a sales call, it's likely a scam. North American Securities Administrators Association Inc. (NASAA) 750 First Street NE, Suite 1140 Washington, DC 20002 202-737-0900 www.nasaa.org NASAA is a voluntary association that helps protect investors from fraud. Social Security Administration (SSA) 800-772-1213 www.ssa.gov Social Security Fraud Hotline P.O. Box 17785 Baltimore, MD 21235 800-269-0271 (10 a.m.–4 p.m. Eastern time) TTY: 866-501-2101 Contact the Social Security Administration for tips on preventing fraud. You can report fraud directly to the Fraud Hotline. U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) Division of Corporation Finance 202-551-3100 www.sec.gov The SEC will answer questions about security transactions and verify registration of securities dealers and firms. The Division of Corporation Finance seeks to ensure that investors are provided with material information in order to make informed investment decisions. CHARITY RATINGS AND REVIEWS These organizations rate and review charities. With many, you can search the charity's name and get the percentage it donates directly to its stated mission. Charity Navigator 139 Harristown Road, Suite 101 Glen Rock, NJ 07452 201-818-1288 www.charitynavigator.org CharityWatch P.O. Box 578460 Chicago, IL 60657 773-529-2300 www.charitywatch.org/home Give.org (BBB Wise Giving Alliance) 3033 Wilson Blvd., Suite 710 Arlington, VA 22201 703-247-9321 www.give.org Givewell 182 Howard Street, No. 208 San Francisco, CA 94105 415-689-5803 www.givewell.org CREDIT-REPORTING AGENCIES Go to www.annualcreditreport.com to get a free annual credit report from each of the three nationwide reporting services—Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion. For the most current results, request a report from each of the companies periodically throughout the year (for example, Equifax on January 1, Experian on May 1, and TransUnion on September 1). You can also set up credit freezes by contacting the three services. Equifax 800-685-1111 www.equifax.com Experian 888-397-3742 www.experian.com TransUnion 800-888-4213 www.transunion.com
